OTSA Talk

When we think about Armenian revolutionary politics in the late Ottoman Empire, we often begin with parties, conspiracies, armed struggle, or the question of nationalism. In this paper, I want to begin somewhere slightly different: with the institutions through which people learned to act collectively. My argument is that revolutionary politics in Bardizag did not simply arrive with the Armenian Revolutionary Federation, or the Social Democrat Hunchakian Party. It developed through a much older and denser institutional world—schools, newspapers, clubs, professional associations, credit institutions, cooperatives, and migrant and political networks. These institutions did not all have revolutionary purposes. But they created practical capacities that revolutionary organizations could draw upon: people learned how to collect money, administer organizations, circulate information, coordinate labor, negotiate with authorities, and turn individual problems into collective ones.

I use the term **collective capacity** to describe this ability to act through institutions. My claim is not that Bardizag possessed a unified revolutionary infrastructure, or that every communal institution was political. Rather, revolutionary politics became possible within a social world that had already developed multiple forms of collective organization. This is particularly important for understanding the ideological relationship between the Hunchaks and the ARF.

The Hunchakian movement emerged in the late nineteenth century from the intersection of Armenian national liberation and European and Russian socialist thought. Its program explicitly connected political freedom with social transformation. The Hunchaks described the existing social order in terms of oppression and "economic slavery," condemned the exploitation of the labor of the majority by a privileged minority, and identified socialism as the ultimate goal of Armenian liberation. Their program called for political freedom, broad democracy, and national independence, but it also imagined the transformation of property and production into collective forms.

For the Hunchaks, therefore, the Armenian question could not be separated from economic exploitation. Ottoman taxation, attacks on land, the appropriation of labor, and political oppression were interconnected forms of domination. National liberation was consequently imagined as part of a larger social revolution.

The Armenian Revolutionary Federation emerged somewhat later and developed a broader revolutionary program. It combined national self-determination and political freedom with social reform and socialist ideas, but it did not reduce revolutionary politics to class struggle. This distinction becomes important in Bardizag because the ARF's political work often moved directly into the organization of everyday economic life.

The two traditions nevertheless shared an important premise: political freedom required collective organization. And in Bardizag, that principle was expressed through institutions as much as through political speeches or clandestine activity.

Yervant Topuzian provides one way of seeing this process from the Hunchakian side.

Topuzian was a teacher at the Armenian school in Bardizag. When he appeared before Ottoman authorities at the age of twenty-two, he identified himself as a Hunchakian and stated that he had joined because the party's program corresponded to his own ideas. He also wrote under the name Panvor and contributed to the Hunchakian weekly *Yergir*. After the restoration of the constitution in 1908, he became an organizer and propagandist in the İzmit region and was associated with *Baykar*, the newspaper of the Bardizag Hunchak branch. He also participated in the party's electoral campaign in the region.

His trajectory is important because it does not fit neatly into the category of the clandestine revolutionary. Topuzian was simultaneously a teacher, journalist, political organizer, and party activist. His political work moved through precisely the institutions that structured everyday communal life: schools, newspapers, elections, and local associations.

His later history also demonstrates how quickly the political possibilities of this world narrowed. In 1913, the Hunchakian leadership adopted a strategy of assassinating prominent CUP figures whom it held responsible for the Adana massacres and believed to be preparing further violence against Armenians. Ottoman authorities uncovered the conspiracy and arrested numerous activists. Topuzian was among the twenty Hunchak activists executed in Constantinople on June 15, 1915.

I emphasize this chronology because it shows two sides of revolutionary politics in Bardizag. On the one hand, revolutionary organization could operate through education, journalism, electoral politics, and public association. On the other, the Ottoman state increasingly interpreted these networks through the categories of conspiracy and security.

The Constitutional Revolution of 1908 made this tension particularly visible. The restoration of the constitution produced an extraordinary expansion of political activity in Bardizag. The ARF and Hunchaks opened clubhouses, and prominent figures such as Simon Zavarian and Khachag Shahrigian visited the town, while the Hunchak representative Sabah Gulian also became active there.

But 1908 did not create collective organization from nothing. It opened political space within a community that already possessed substantial institutional resources.

Consider the scale of educational life. In 1909–1910, Bardizag had the Nerses-Shoushanian coeducational community school, kindergartens, the Mekhitarian school, the American High School, and the Favre Boys' Home. The Nerses-Shoushanian school alone enrolled hundreds of boys and girls. Education was therefore not simply a private or familial concern. It was a major form of communal organization.

The press produced another layer of this institutional world. Bardizag produced at least twenty-one newspapers and periodicals between the 1840s and 1915. Their subjects extended well beyond politics—to education, agriculture, prices, labor, and everyday social problems.

This matters because the press helped transform dispersed experiences into shared problems. A newspaper could take something experienced privately—a shortage of school supplies, the price of food, the organization of education—and place it within a collective conversation about responsibility and possible solutions.

Meghou, the ARF-affiliated paper published in Bardizag between 1911 and 1914, is particularly revealing. Its pages show political organization operating alongside discussions of education, agriculture, prices, labor, and community institutions. The newspaper was therefore not simply transmitting an ideology formulated elsewhere. It was one of the places where political ideas acquired local meaning.

The Teachers' Association offers an especially useful example. A 1913 article in *Meghou* criticized the separation between teachers at the American High School and those at the Armenian National Primary School. Although the institutions served the same community, teachers had limited opportunities for coordination. The proposed Teachers' Union would create regular consultation, reciprocal classroom visits, and curricular coordination.

I do not want to claim that the Teachers' Association was itself a revolutionary organization. The evidence does not establish that. What it shows is something more interesting: the organization of educational labor could create forms of coordination that were politically significant without being explicitly political.

This becomes clearer when we look at a 1914 photograph of the Bardizag Armenian Teachers' Association. A copy of *Azadamard*, the ARF-affiliated Constantinople daily, appears among the group. An Ottoman report also accused people in Bardizag of supporting and providing information to the paper.

The evidence does not prove that the teachers' organization was an ARF organization. But it demonstrates how easily educational, professional, and political networks could overlap. Schools, teachers, newspapers, and political organizations existed within the same social field.

The state recognized this interconnectedness as well.

An ARF report from 1910 describes arrests following an alleged clash on the customs road. Gendarmes and police surrounded coffeehouses, reading rooms, markets, and government offices and detained fifteen people. Relatives and other residents mobilized to secure their release.

What is striking here is not simply the arrest of suspected revolutionaries. It is the range of spaces that became objects of surveillance. Coffeehouses and reading rooms were places of sociability and political discussion; markets connected people through economic exchange; families mobilized around detainees; information circulated through local relationships.

The authorities were therefore confronting not just individual revolutionaries but a connected social world.

And this brings us to the economic institutions that I think are essential to understanding revolutionary politics in Bardizag.

If we look only at parties and political organizations, we miss an important part of what revolutionary politics meant in practice. The ARF's activities increasingly addressed the material relations through which people experienced dependence: credit, wages, production, and consumption.

The People's Bank is one example. According to its founder's account, poorer villagers were losing much of their income to creditors who charged extremely high interest. Debt could accumulate until people were forced to sell their possessions under unfavorable conditions. The response was to establish a People's Bank based on collective contributions. Shares were set at twenty tahegans, with an initial goal of raising 1,000 liras. Nearly 5,000 shares were reportedly sold, many villagers purchasing five or ten shares. Within three months, the bank was extending small loans of one to three liras against shares or the guarantee of a trusted individual. The importance of the bank is not that it abolished capitalism or debt. It did neither. The loans were still monetary loans, and the bank remained within the market.

What changed was the social organization of access to credit. Debt was no longer treated exclusively as a private relationship between an individual borrower and an individual creditor. It became a collective economic problem that could be addressed through a communal institution.

The Dashnaktsagan retail cooperative worked through a similar logic, but at the level of consumption. The Bardizag ARF committee was concerned about the price of meat, flour, and other basic necessities. It argued that access to adequate food should be treated as a collective question rather than simply as a matter of individual purchasing power. The cooperative was established in May 1911. One hundred people joined as founding members. Membership required an initial payment of twenty paras and a weekly contribution of one para for five years. The cooperative sought to purchase quality goods at reasonable prices, distribute benefits according to purchases, and eventually establish a bakery.

Its administration was entrusted to Karnig Bodourian, who managed the Builders' Association and had also founded a Carpenters' Association. This is significant because it connects the cooperative to the broader associational world of Bardizag rather than treating it as an isolated ARF project.

Local grocers strongly resisted the cooperative.

Again, the point is not that this institution existed outside the market. It did not. Its significance was that it attempted to reorganize how people participated in the market. A question that ordinarily appeared as an individual household problem—the price of food—became a question of collective organization.

The same logic appears even more directly in the ARF correspondence concerning worker-artisans in March 1913.

The local committee discussed the problem of workers whose individual efforts within existing factories had produced limited results. One letter observed that "it is difficult to operate on wages alone." The proposed alternative was to organize work through individual contracts and to provide financial support for tools, materials, and other expenses.

The committee even considered whether the party, under the guarantee of the local committee, could allocate as much as 100 gold liras to such an enterprise.

The correspondence explicitly addressed the relationship between workers and factory owners. Individual workers lacked sufficient leverage, and the committee considered whether organizing production differently could increase their bargaining power.

Here, the revolutionary organization was not simply asking workers to support a political program. It was attempting to intervene in the material organization of labor itself.

Credit, consumption, and production therefore reveal three different dimensions of the same problem.

The People's Bank addressed dependence on creditors.

The cooperative addressed dependence within the purchase of everyday necessities.

The worker-artisan initiative addressed dependence within wage labor and relations with factory owners.

None of these institutions created a socialist economy. None eliminated class relations. And they should not be read as evidence of a coherent alternative economic system.

Their significance lies in the attempt to change the **social organization of dependence**.

This is where I think the ideological history of the Hunchaks and the ARF becomes especially useful. The Hunchakian language of exploitation and socialism gave political meaning to relations between labor and capital, property and production. The ARF's broader revolutionary politics could translate questions of social justice into institutions that organized credit, consumption, labor, education, and information.

In Bardizag, then, ideology and institution-building were not separate processes.

A revolutionary idea became meaningful when it could be attached to an institutional practice.

The idea that workers should have greater control over their labor could become a discussion about contracts, tools, and capital.

The idea that economic exploitation should be challenged could become a People's Bank.

The idea that ordinary people had collective rights could become a cooperative for food.

The idea that education was a communal responsibility could become an association coordinating teachers.

And political ideas themselves could circulate through newspapers, reading rooms, schools, and clubs.

This is what I mean by collective capacity.

It was the practical ability to do things together that individuals could not easily do alone: pool money, organize production, circulate information, coordinate professional work, negotiate with authorities, and create institutions capable of surviving beyond a single political meeting.

The revolutionary significance of these institutions therefore lies not simply in whether they were formally affiliated with a political party. It lies in how they altered the terrain on which political action became possible.

They created relationships of trust and coordination. They gave people experience in administration and collective decision-making. They transformed individual problems into shared questions. And, crucially, they offered mechanisms through which people could contest forms of dependence that structured everyday life.

This also helps explain why the destruction of Bardizag in 1915 was not simply the removal of a population. It dismantled an institutional world: schools, newspapers, associations, economic organizations, networks of credit, and the relationships that connected them.

The history of revolutionary politics in Bardizag is therefore not only a history of parties, conspiracies, or political violence.

It is also a history of institution-building.

The Hunchaks and the ARF brought competing but overlapping languages of socialism, national liberation, democracy, and social justice into a community that already possessed substantial capacities for collective organization. In Bardizag, those ideas were worked out through the practical problems of education, information, credit, consumption, production, and labor.

The revolutionary question was consequently larger than who would control the state.

It was also a question of who would control the conditions of everyday life—and whether those conditions would remain organized through individualized relations of dependence or could increasingly become objects of collective action.